

R PROMISE

however, no one can deliver a change in attitude and action better than them.

The youth have always been agents of change. Major changes in history have been introduced by youthful energy, by leaders of political movements, in science and social activism. Whatever the changes, good or bad, the path has been broken by the youth and if it is a well-charted path, the change has a wider horizon. But with India being such a large country, the changes are seen only in a corner, and when the efforts are not fully coordinated, they don't produce the effect. We often consider only the urban and elite youth as agents of change, but there is a large number of young people, non-urban and non-elite, who are rooted in a different atmosphere and have a deeper understanding of traditional India. It is this youth that have to be an instrument of change.

Mobilising the youth can come only through the vision of the leaders. Look at Mahatma Gandhi and the group of youthful

leaders he selected, be it Jawaharlal Nehru, Jayaprakash Narayan or Rajendra Prasad. Look at revolutionaries like Bhagat Singh, Chandrashekhar Azad or Ashfaqullah Khan. They all were chosen through the vision of the elderly. The problem arises when the elderly think what they are doing is the last word and there is no need for change. Today's youth is politically cynical because the intellectual capacities, personal conduct and vision of the leaders don't interest them. It is also because the urban, educated young are, by and large, delinked from reality. They don't realise the condition of millions of people and there is no system of education that can give them the right information.

When I was in college, we were energised by a desire to see an independent India. We fought against British rule and for social changes like education for women and a ban on untouchability. Our vision wasn't to become an MP or MLA but to create a new society, a new India. Today's youth doesn't lack the passion to create political change. On the contrary, the passion is there, but the channelling system to use that in a focused manner is missing. So, after some time that passion dies out. The present generation has little exposure to India's history and achievements. They don't even understand India's weaknesses. Unless you create a picture of who you are, how can you create change? The education and political systems, unfortunately, don't instill a sense of confidence in us about our achievements or a critical appreciation of our weaknesses.

I have travelled all across the world and I can say that the Indian youth are second to none. But their roots are at fault. The young are in a wilderness. But the moment they are given this sense of history and time, and they realise India's inner consciousness, there will be a tremendous explosion of energy and the great propulsion of a new India. Everything that is outmoded and worn will be thrown out then, and that which is essential to India will be retained. A new India will come. And for that India is waiting.

as told to Chitra Subramanyam



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**MURLI MANOHAR
JOSHI, MP, 75**



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